What a move costs an attacker

Usage, playing time and luck after a move, Big-5, 2014–15 to 2024–25

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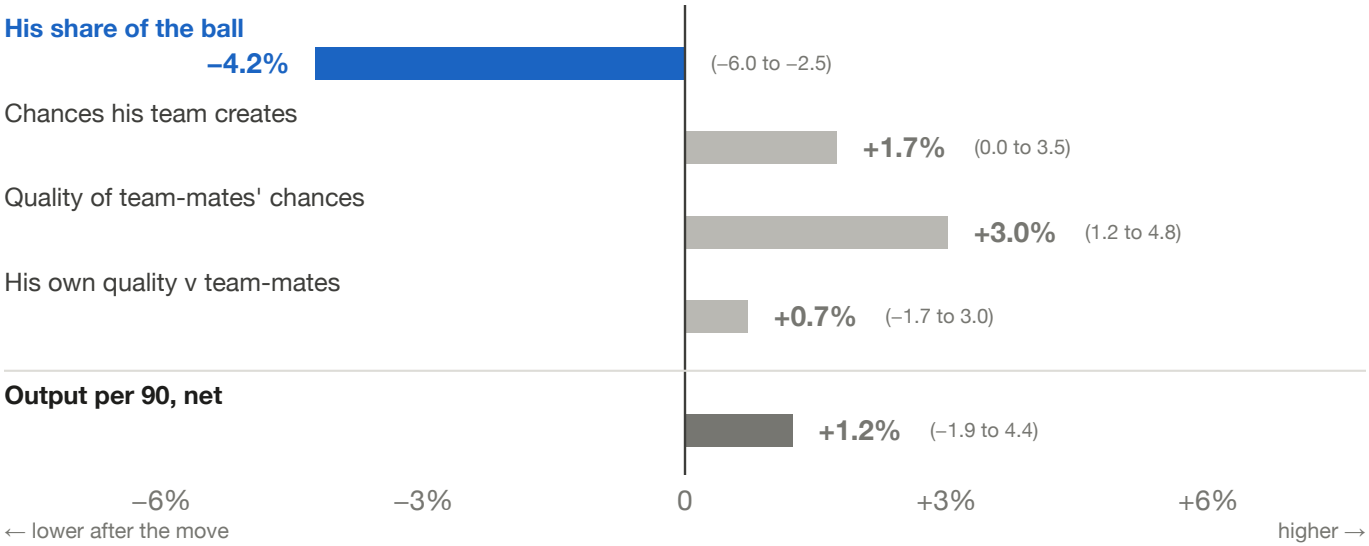
After a move between Big-5 clubs, 44% of attackers flop or fall below 900 league minutes the next season, against 33% of stayers (+11.8 points (+8.0 to +15.4) matched on last season; Opta +14.0). His share of his team's shots and shot-assists falls by –4.2% (–6.0% to –2.5%), partly set pieces: in open play –2.6%. If he keeps playing, output per 90 holds (+1.2%; Opta –0.7%).

+11.8 pts
flop or lost his place, movers v stayers, matched

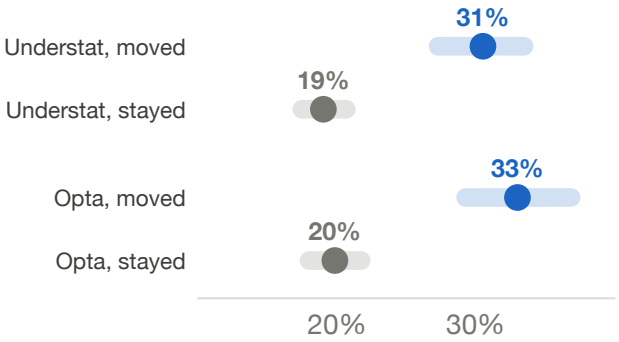
31% v 19%
under 900 league minutes next season, movers v stayers

–4.2%
share of shots and shot-assists, matched

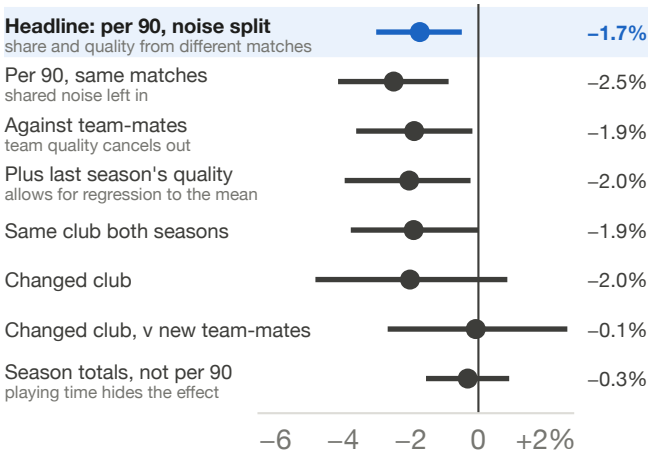
What a move does, against stayers with the same last season (per 90)



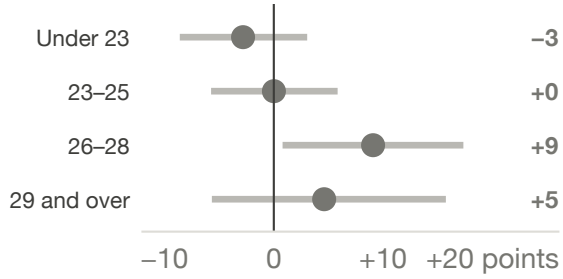
Below 900 league minutes the next season



Same player, 5 points more of the ball

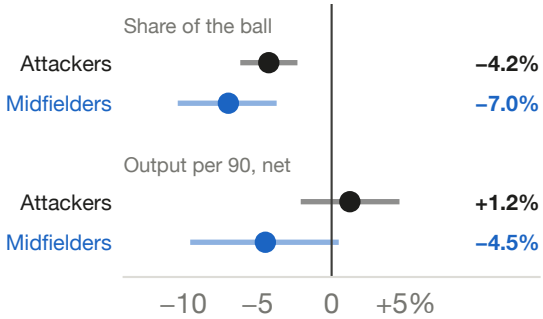


Flop rate by age, moved minus stayed (points)



No age band survives the correction for 11 tests.

After a move: attackers v midfielders (matched)



Limits: observational and exploratory, nothing pre-registered; shots and shot-assists only; the four-part split is accounting; no betting, fantasy or prop market tested, so no trading signal. Big-5: top divisions of England, Spain, Italy, Germany, France.
Data: Understat, Opta via FBref, Transfermarkt. 95% intervals.

github.com/benedictprimmer-web/football-usage-efficiency